

TWO PATHS TO HOME

The standard ii-V-I and the Backdoor ii-V both resolve to Cmaj7 — but they take completely different emotional routes to get there.

PATH 1 — STANDARD

THE II-V-I



Bass: D → G → C

BASS MOTION

Down a 5th (D → G), then down a 5th again (G → C). The "double fifth drop" — maximally conclusive, traditional Western motion.

HARMONIC CHARACTER

Crisp, direct, jazzy. The tritone inside G7 creates urgent, clear-cut tension that snaps directly into resolution. No ambiguity.

CRISP

DIRECT

CONCLUSIVE

JAZZY

Standard jazz cadences, "Autumn Leaves," countless standard tunes — the baseline of tonal harmony.

PATH 2 — BACKDOOR

THE BACKDOOR II-V-I



Bass: F → B $\flat$ → C

BASS MOTION

Down a 5th (F → B $\flat$), then up a step (B $\flat$ → C). The bass "sneaks in" from below — a half step below tonic. Unexpected, warm, chromatic.

HARMONIC CHARACTER

Both Fm7 and B $\flat$ 7 are borrowed from parallel minor — creating a consistently "borrowed" emotional warmth throughout the approach. Softer resolution.

WARM

SMOOTH

CINEMATIC

EMOTIONALLY RICH

"Knocks Me Off My Feet" — Stevie Wonder. R&B ballads, neo-soul, gospel.

"Both resolve to Cmaj7. The difference is the emotional temperature of the journey — standard ii-V-I = arriving by jet, Backdoor ii-V = arriving by a warm night drive."

AT A GLANCE — KEY DIFFERENCES

STANDARD II-V-I

- Diatonic ii chord (Dm7 — in key)
- Tritone in V7 creates strong pull
- Bass descends by two 5ths
- Crisp, direct, "expected"
- Works in any style, especially jazz

BACKDOOR II-V-I

- Borrowed iv- chord (Fm7 — from minor)
- B $\flat$ 7 is tritone sub of E7 (SubV7/vi)
- Bass: 5th down then step up to tonic
- Warm, "surprising but inevitable"
- R&B, gospel, neo-soul, ballads